

Central Intelligence Agency



Washington, D.C. 20505

6 August 2025

J Ader
MuckRock News
DEPT MR 117678
263 Huntington Avenue
Boston, MA 02115
117678-51947080@requests.muckrock.com

Reference: F-2021-02228

Dear Requester:

This letter is a final response to your 16 August 2021 Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) request for **all records mentioning Babrak Karmal**. We processed your request in accordance with the FOIA (5 U.S.C. § 552, as amended, and the CIA Information Act, 50 U.S.C. § 3141, as amended).

We completed a thorough search for records responsive to your request and located the enclosed five documents that are releasable in segregable form with deletions made on the basis of FOIA exemptions (b)(1), (b)(3), and/or (b)(6). Exemption (b)(3) pertains to information exempt from disclosure by statute. The relevant statutes are Section 6 of the Central Intelligence Agency Act of 1949, as amended, and Section 102A(i)(1) of the National Security Act of 1947, as amended.

As the CIA Information and Privacy Coordinator, I am the CIA official responsible for this determination. You have the right to appeal this response to the Agency Release Panel, in my care, within 90 days from the date of this letter. Please explain the basis for your appeal.

Please be advised that you may also seek dispute-resolution services from the CIA FOIA Public Liaison or from the Office of Government Information Services (OGIS) of the National Archives and Records Administration. OGIS offers mediation services to help resolve disputes between FOIA requesters and Federal agencies.

To contact CIA directly with questions or to appeal the CIA's response to the Agency Release Panel:	To contact the Office of Government Information Services (OGIS) for mediation or with questions:
Information and Privacy Coordinator Central Intelligence Agency Washington, DC 20505 TEL: (703) 613-1287 FAX: (703) 613-3007	Office of Government Information Services National Archives and Records Administration 8601 Adelphi Road – OGIS College Park, MD 20740-6001 TEL: (202) 741-5770 FAX: (202) 741-5769 / ogis@nara.gov

In processing your request, we also located numerous mentions of the subject of your request in documents already available to you on the CIA's Electronic Reading Room (www.CIA.gov/readingroom). We suggest you use the Advanced Search feature with the search string "Babrak Karmal"~2 to locate the additional material.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read "Stephen Glenn", with a stylized flourish at the end.

Stephen Glenn
Information and Privacy Coordinator

Enclosures

KARMAL, Babrak

AF

(b)(3)

(BABRAK Karmal)
(Phonetic: BaBRAK)

AFGHANISTAN

(b)(3)

President, Revolutionary Council
(since December 1979)

Addressed as:
Mr. President



©

Despite constant rumors of his imminent removal, Babrak Karmal remains the Soviet Union's number-one in Afghanistan. He was installed as his country's leader after a bloody Soviet-engineered coup in 1979. In addition to the presidency, he served as Prime Minister from December 1979 until June 1981 and has been secretary general of the ruling People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA) since December 1979.

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

he has only limited popularity among his countrymen.

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

Since taking office Babrak has tried to gain legitimacy and international recognition for his government. He has broadened the government's political base by including some military leaders and non-Communists in the Cabinet and the Revolutionary Council (the main executive and quasi-legislative body). His efforts so far have not satisfied the general populace, who oppose Soviet intervention; in the eyes of his own people, as well as of the world in general,

(b)(3)

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

Communist Connection

Babrak, a longtime Communist, began his leftwing activities around 1950 as a student at Kabul University. Arrested for leftist agitation on campus, he was jailed during 1952-56. After his release he became an active Communist; he joined the PDPA when it was formed in 1965. In 1967 the PDPA split over differences in party strategy. Babrak and his followers favored increased political agitation against the monarchy and formed the Parcham (Banner) faction, while the more cautious members formed the Khalq (People) faction. In 1977 he returned to the party fold and was named its vice chairman.

(b)(3)

(b)(3)

(cont.)
CR M 82-12822

(b)(3)

When the Communists seized control in April 1978, Babrak became a deputy prime minister and vice chairman of the Revolutionary Council and appeared to be the second most important figure in the regime. In late June and early July, however, the leaders of Babrak's Parcham faction were exiled. Babrak was sent to Czechoslovakia as Ambassador and, after being dismissed in September, remained in Eastern Europe until [redacted] December 1979. [redacted]

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

Career and Personal Data

(b)(3)

Babrak comes from a prominent family in Pushtunistan, a rural area that borders Pakistan, and may be related to the late President Mohammad Daoud. In 1949 he entered the law faculty at Kabul University. After his release from jail in 1956, he received a law degree (1957) and served in the Army for a year (1958). From 1958 until 1965 he was a minor official in the Planning Ministry. In 1965 Babrak won a seat in Parliament, where he displayed his skills as an orator and political tactician. He was defeated in 1966 but regained his seat in 1969. His career in Parliament ended in 1973, when the legislature was dissolved. Babrak remained out of the public eye until 1978. [redacted]

(b)(3)

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

[redacted] He speaks several Afghan dialects, English, and some German. Babrak, who is about 53, may be married and have four children. [redacted]

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

(b)(6)

[redacted] He has five brothers, two of whom are active Communists. [redacted]

(b)(3)

21 May 1982

(b)(3)

BABRAK Karmal
(Phonetic: baBRAK)

AFGHANISTAN

*President, Revolutionary
Council
(since December 1979)*

*Addressed as:
Mr. President*



Babrak Karmal is the Soviet Union's number-one [redacted] in Afghanistan. [redacted]

[redacted] he has only limited popularity among his countrymen. Since being installed as his country's leader after a bloody Soviet-engineered coup in 1979, Babrak has tried to gain legitimacy and international recognition for his government.

[redacted] He has broadened the government's political base by including some military leaders and non-Communists in the Cabinet and the Revolutionary Council (the main executive and quasi-legislative body). [redacted] his efforts so far have not satisfied the general populace, who oppose Soviet intervention: in the eyes of his own people, as well as of the world in general [redacted]

Babrak has been general secretary of the ruling People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA) since December 1979. He is a member of the dominant Parcham (Banner) faction. Some members of his government [redacted] belong to the Khalq (People) faction. The PDPA is a bitterly divided party; and [redacted] this split, which has led to violent clashes even among senior ministers, has become public knowledge. [redacted] Babrak has even chastised members of both factions publicly, hoping to eliminate the rivalry and political turmoil the split has caused. [redacted]

Communist Connection

Babrak, a longtime Communist, began his leftwing activities in about 1950 as a student at Kabul University. Arrested for leftist agitation on campus, he was jailed during 1952-56. He joined the PDPA when it was formed in 1965. In 1967 the PDPA split over differences in party strategy. Babrak and his followers favored increased political agitation against the monarchy and formed the Parcham faction, while the more cautious members formed the Khalq faction. In 1977 Babrak returned to the party fold and was named its vice chairman. [redacted]

When the Communists seized control in April 1978, Babrak became a deputy prime minister and vice chairman of the Revolutionary Council and appeared to be the second most important figure in the regime. In late June and early July, however, he and other leaders of the Parcham faction were exiled. Babrak was sent to Czechoslovakia as

(cont.)
CR M 83-15570

[redacted] (b)(3)
[redacted] (b)(1)
Ambassador and, after being dismissed in September, remained in Eastern Europe until [redacted] (b)(3)
[redacted] December 1979. In addition to the presidency, he held the
prime ministership until June 1981. [redacted] (b)(3)

Career and Personal Data

In 1949 Babrak entered the Law Faculty at Kabul University. After his release from jail in 1956, he received a law degree and served in the Army for a year. From 1958 until 1965 he was a minor official in the Planning Ministry. In 1965 Babrak won a seat in Parliament, where he displayed his skills as an orator and political tactician. He was defeated in 1966 but regained his seat in 1969. His career in Parliament ended in 1973, when the legislature was dissolved. Babrak then remained out of the public eye until 1978.

[redacted] (b)(1)
[redacted] (b)(3)
[redacted] ambitious, intelligent, and affable. [redacted]
[redacted] he is an excellent speaker, although he tends to dominate a conversation. [redacted]
[redacted] He speaks several Afghan
dialects, English, and some German. He has traveled to most of the East European countries
and to Mongolia on state visits. He often visits Moscow for consultations as well as for
vacations [redacted] (b)(1)
[redacted] Babrak, who is about 54, is married and has several (b)(3)
children. [redacted]
[redacted]

Babrak comes from a prominent family in Pushtunistan (he may be related to the late President Mohammad Daoud). His father was an important general until the monarchy was overthrown in 1953 [redacted]

[redacted] Babrak has five brothers, one of whom is a high-ranking member of the PDPA [redacted] (b)(1)
(b)(3)

12 October 1983

BF

(**BABRAK Karmal**)
(Phonetic: baBRAK)

AFGHANISTAN

*President, Revolutionary
Council
(since December 1979)*

*Addressed as:
Mr. President*



(b)(1)
(b)(3)

Since the installation of longtime Communist Babrak Karmal as his country's leader following a bloody Soviet-engineered coup and invasion, he has

only limited popularity among his countrymen. Babrak has tried to gain legitimacy and international recognition for his government, but

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

his attempts to bolster his image and that of his government have continually failed. He has broadened the government's political base by including some military leaders and non-Communists in the Cabinet and the Revolutionary Council (the main executive and quasi-legislative body). His efforts so far have not satisfied the general populace, who oppose Soviet intervention; in the eyes of his own people, as well as of the world in general. Since he took office there have been constant rumors that his removal is imminent.

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

(b)(3)

Babrak has been general secretary of the ruling People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA) since he assumed office. The PDPA is a bitterly divided party, and this split, which has led to violent clashes even among senior ministers, has become public knowledge. Babrak has chastised members of both factions publicly, hoping to eliminate the rivalry and political turmoil the split has caused.

(b)(3)

Communist Connection

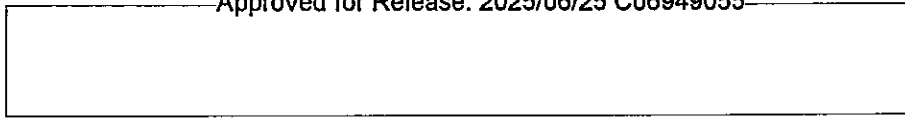
In 1949 Babrak entered the Law Faculty at Kabul University, where he began his leftwing activities about a year later. Arrested for leftist agitation on campus, he was jailed during 1952-56. After his release, he received a law degree and served in the Army for a year. From 1958 until 1965 he was a minor official in the Planning Ministry. Babrak joined the PDPA when it was formed in 1965 and won a seat in parliament the same year. There he displayed his skills as an orator and political tactician. He was defeated in 1966 but regained his seat in 1969. Meanwhile, in 1967 the PDPA split over differences in party strategy. Babrak and his followers favored increased political agitation against the monarchy and formed the Parchami faction, while the more cautious members formed the Khalqi faction. In 1977 Babrak returned to the party fold and was named its vice chairman.

(b)(3)

Babrak's career in parliament had ended in 1973, when the legislature was dissolved. He then remained out of the public eye until 1978. When the Communists seized control in April of that year, he became a deputy prime minister and vice chairman of the Revolutionary Council and appeared to be the second most important figure in the regime. In late June and early July, however, he and other leaders of the Parchami faction were exiled. Babrak was sent to Czechoslovakia as Ambassador and, after being dismissed in

(cont.)
CR M 85-10938

(b)(3)



(b)(3)

September, sought asylum in Eastern Europe, remaining until [redacted] (b)(1)
[redacted] December 1979. In addition to the presidency, he held the prime-ministership until (b)(3)
June 1981. [redacted]

(b)(3)

Personal Data

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

[redacted] ambitious, intelligent, and affable, although
he tends to dominate a conversation. His speeches have been known to last as long as six
hours. [redacted] Babrak speaks several Afghan dialects,
English, and some German. He has traveled to most of the East European countries and to
Mongolia on state visits. He often visits Moscow for consultations as well as for vacations

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

[redacted] Babrak, who is about 56, has several children. [redacted]

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

Babrak comes from a prominent Pashtun family (he may be related to the late
President Mohammad Daoud). His father was an important general until the monarchy was
overthrown in 1973 [redacted]

(b)(3)

(b)(1)

[redacted] Babrak has five brothers, one of whom is a high-ranking member of the
PDPA. [redacted]

(b)(3)

19 February 1985



(b)(3)

BABRAK, Kama/

National
Foreign
Assessment
Center~~Secret~~

AF

1) AC/NEA TB

2) AC/NEA

3) C/AF

FYI - RETURN OR DESTROY -

HOL HAS INDEXING COPY

SKZ O

UB-~~XXXXXXXXXX~~

Afghanistan: The Babrak Government

An Intelligence Memorandum

~~Secret~~PA 79-10610
December 1979

Copy 122

Warning Notice

**Intelligence Sources
and Methods Involved
(WNINTEL)**

**National Security
Information**

**Unauthorized Disclosure
Subject to Criminal Sanctions**

Dissemination Control Abbreviations	NOFORN (NF)	Not Releasable to Foreign Nationals
	NOCONTRACT (NC)	Not Releasable to Contractors or Contractor/Consultants
	PROPIN (PF)	Caution—Proprietary Information Involved
	NFIBONLY (NO)	NFIB Departments Only
	ORCON (OC)	Dissemination and Extraction of Information Controlled by Originator
	REL...	This Information Has Been Authorized for Release to...
	FGI	Foreign Government Information
(b)(3)	A microfiche copy of this document is available from OCR/DSB printed copies from PPG/RDB.	Derivative classification by 032931 Review 20 years from date Derived from multiple sources
(b)(3)	Regular reports in either microfiche or printed form can also be arranged through PPG/RDB.	(b)(3)

All material on this page
is unclassified.

~~Secret~~

(b)(3)

**Afghanistan:
The Babrak Government**

(b)(3)

Summary

The Soviet-installed government of Prime Minister Babrak Karmal is dominated by members of his Parcham faction of the People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan, but leftist military officers who overthrew President Daoud in April 1978 and installed the first PDPA government are also important participants. Many of the Cabinet members and the Parchamists who are helping with security in Kabul have been hiding in the Soviet Embassy in Afghanistan for up to a year. Included in this category are Sherjan Mazduryar, Minister of Transport, and Revolutionary Council member Mohammad Aslam Watanjar, who reportedly fled to the Soviet Embassy after the mid-September coup in which Amin deposed Taraki.

(b)(3)

There are also several men in the Cabinet who have not been closely tied to either Parcham or the military leftists in the past, and a few who seem to have been closer to the party's Khalq faction—headed by the late Presidents Taraki and Amin—than to Parcham. Almost all, however, seem to have had a good reason to hate Amin and to have cooperated in his overthrow.

(b)(3)

So far the Babrak government has announced a partial list of the Cabinet and some members of the Revolutionary Council (in theory a supervisory, quasi-legislative body) and publicly designated three individuals as "party members," a term possibly intended to recognize their importance without granting them any authority. (c)

The most important Cabinet positions appear to have been given to some of the least important men. The two Deputy Prime Ministers and the Defense, Interior, Finance, and Foreign Ministers are all men of relatively little importance and presumably can be controlled easily. Far more important individuals—such as Abdul Qader, Nur Ahmad Nur, and Mohammad Aslam Watanjar have not been included in the Cabinet, although they are members of the Revolutionary Council.

(b)(3)

(b)(3)

(b)(6)

The author of this paper is [] of the Near East - South Asia Division, Office of Political Analysis.

(b)(3)

(b)(3)

~~Secret~~

(b)(3)

Afghanistan:
The Babrak Government ☐

(b)(3)

BF x i, l

The Parchamists



(Babrak Karmal) Prime Minister, Secretary General of the People's Democratic Party, President of the Revolutionary Council

Babrak, as he is usually known, is the dominant figure in the new Afghan Government. He was born in 1929 to a prominent Pushtun family—his father was a general and provincial governor—and was educated at Kabul University. He was jailed for political agitation in 1952 and while in prison fell under the influence of Mir Akbar Khaibar, a leading Afghan Communist theoretician. Until Khaibar's murder in April 1978, Babrak was generally considered to be a front man for his mentor. ☐

(b)(3)

Khaibar's Parcham faction, unlike Taraki's Khalquists, advocated participation in the political process, and in 1965 Babrak was one of three Parchamists elected to Parliament. His activities in Parliament probably made him better known to the public than any other Afghan Marxist. He instigated serious student disorders that forced the resignation of Prime Minister Yusuf in 1965 and was hospitalized for six weeks in 1966 after a beating by conservative deputies. He was reelected to Parliament in 1969 with student support. High points of his second term were a major speech during a confidence debate in 1971 in which he attacked the royal family and the United States, and a demonstration—perhaps the largest ever in Afghanistan—he organized in 1973 to protest a water-sharing agreement with Iran. ☐

(b)(3)

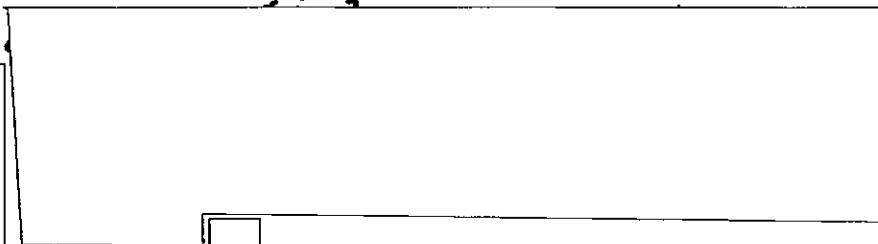
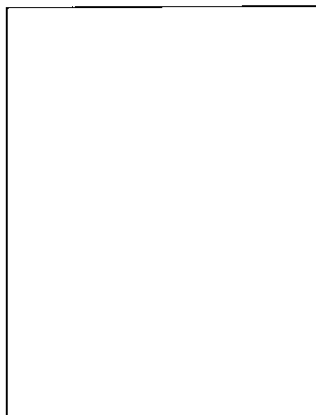
Following the overthrow of the monarchy in 1973, Babrak refrained from public activity until the murder of Khaibar in April 1978. His emotional funeral speech—surprisingly broadcast by the government—and the major demonstration to protest the killing led to the arrest of Marxist leaders. The arrests in turn led to the Marxist coup. ☐

(b)(3)

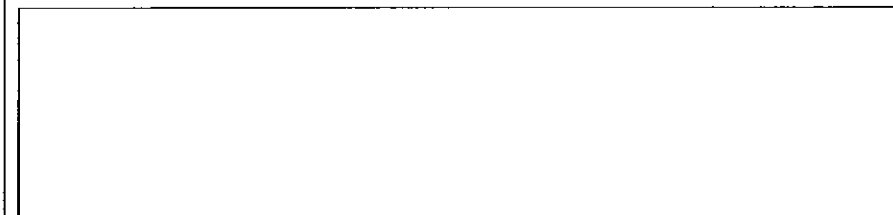
As the leader of the Parcham faction, Babrak became Deputy Prime Minister in the new government. He was quickly outmaneuvered by the Khalqist leaders—President Taraki and Foreign Minister Amin—and in July was exiled as Ambassador to Czechoslovakia. He was ordered to return home to stand trial for coup plotting in September, but remained outside Afghanistan—primarily in Prague—until his installation as Prime Minister in December 1979. ☐

(b)(3)

~~Secret~~

~~Secret~~(b)(1)
(b)(3)

(b)(3)



(b)(3)

(b)(1)
(b)(3)(b)(1)
(b)(3)

(b)(3)



** i, 2*
(**Anahita Ratebzad**) **Minister of Education**

Anahita, born in 1929, claims to be the first Afghan woman to be educated in the United States. She studied nursing in Chicago when she and her husband—Babrak's uncle—lived there in 1951-53. She is an excellent and acerbic public speaker. In public she appears to be a fiery radical leftist and feminist, but in private she is reportedly pleasant, reasonable, and thoughtful. 

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

Anahita attended Kabul University Medical College, but it is not known whether she received a degree. She taught there and at a nursing school before being elected to Parliament in 1965. 

(b)(3)

(b)(3)

When the Marxists seized power, she was named Minister of Social Affairs, but in July 1978 she was reassigned as Ambassador to Yugoslavia. She apparently remained in Eastern Europe when she was recalled to stand trial. 

(b)(3)

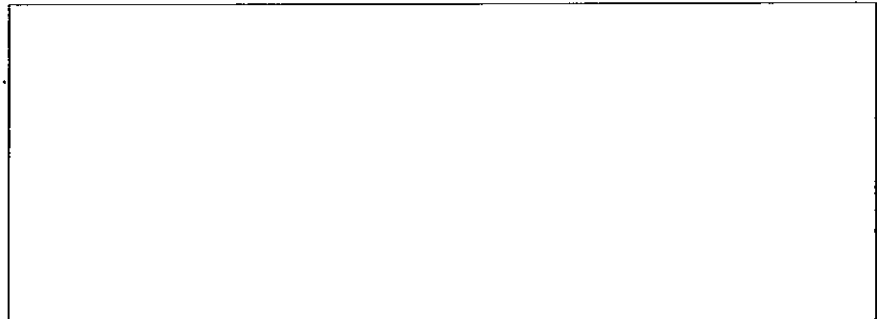
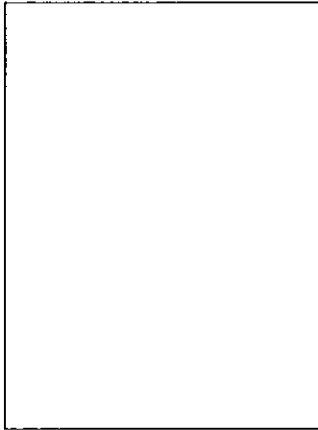


(b)(3)

(b)(1)
(b)(3)~~Secret~~

~~Secret~~

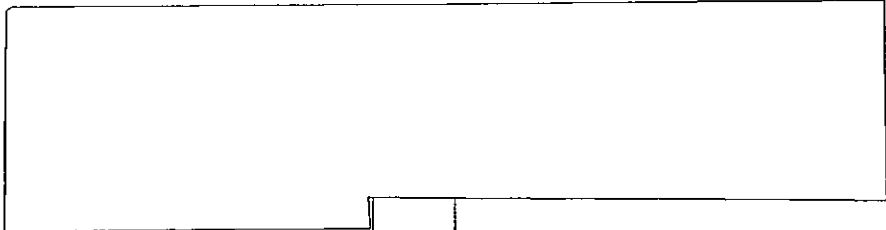
(b)(3)



(b)(1)
(b)(3)

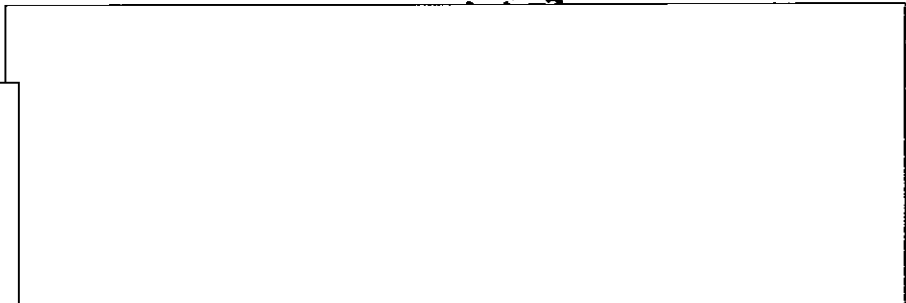


(b)(3)
(b)(3)

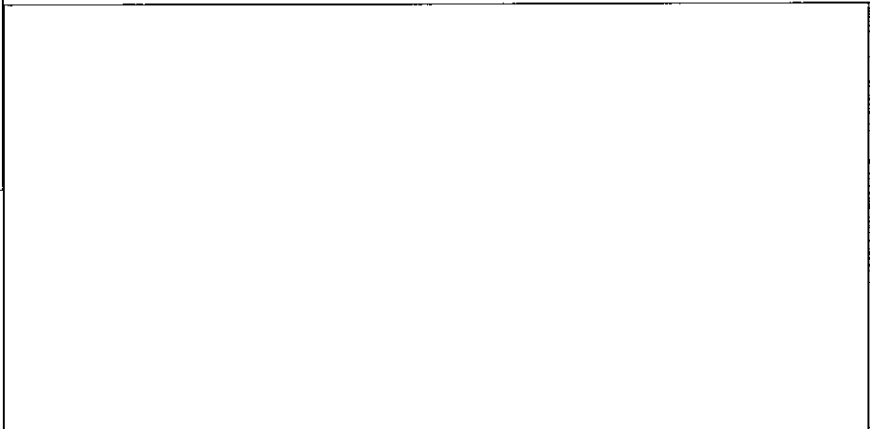
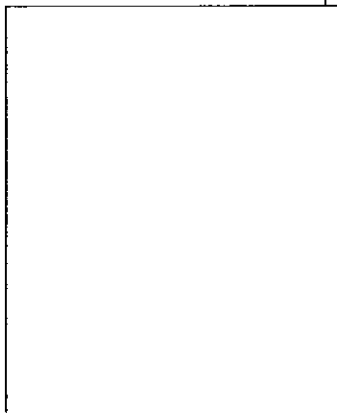


(b)(3)

(b)(3)



(b)(3)
(b)(1)
(b)(3)



(b)(1)
(b)(3)

~~Secret~~

~~Secret~~

x 5, 4
Lt. Col. Sherjan Mazduryar Minister of Transport

Mazduryar, about 40, at one time seemed to be completely trusted by Taraki and Amin, and simultaneously held the politically most important commands in the Army—the Army Corps in the Kabul area, the Kabul Garrison, and one of the two armored brigades near Kabul. When his apparently close friend Watanjar was made Chief of Staff, Mazduryar replaced him as Interior Minister. It has never been clear whether his appointment to this key ministry reflected continuing trust or was designed to deprive him of control of troops in the Kabul area. Although he was believed loyal to Amin, the latter apparently suspected he was involved in Soviet efforts to eliminate Amin, and in July 1979 Amin made him Minister of Frontier Affairs, one of the least important posts in the Cabinet. Mazduryar went into hiding when Taraki was overthrown. ☐

(b)(3)

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

x 5, 4
Colonel Mohammad Rafi Minister of National Defense

Rafi, about 35, participated in the armored attack on the palace in April 1978 and was made Minister of Public Works. Although Rafi was not important enough to be a serious threat, he was arrested for antigovernment plotting in August 1978. ☐

(b)(3)

~~Secret~~

~~Secret~~

x i, 5
Sayed Mohammad Gulabzoi, Minister of Interior

Gulabzoi, about 30, is a former enlisted aircraft instrument mechanic who was commissioned for his part in the 1973 coup. He may have subsequently washed out of pilot training in the USSR. Prior to the 1978 coup, he reportedly was transferred to the reserves for organizing Air Force officers in support of Taraki and played a key liaison role in organizing the 1978 coup. All party leaders were in jail at that time. He was made Minister of Communications in July 1978 and may not have been in the original Marxist Cabinet only because he was badly wounded during the coup. He disappeared—and may have fled to the USSR—after Amin overthrew Taraki. []

(b)(3)

Others



i. 5
Assadullah Sarwari, Deputy Prime Minister, Vice President of the Revolutionary Council

Assadullah, a former helicopter pilot trained in the USSR, assisted Amin with party organization prior to the 1978 coup. He was made director of the Department of National Protection—a secret police force reporting directly to the Prime Minister—after the Marxists seized control. In October 1978 his department was combined with similar organizations that had been under the Defense and Interior Ministries to form the Afghan Intelligence and Security Command (ACGSA). Soviet advisers were closely involved in ACGSA activities, perhaps more so than in any other part of the government. Assadullah headed ACGSA until the overthrow of Taraki in September 1979, when he went into hiding. The organization was renamed the Workers Intelligence Institute (KAM) and headed by President Amin's nephew. []

(b)(3)



i. 5, 6
Soltan Ali Keshtmand, Deputy Prime Minister, Minister of Planning, Vice President of the Revolutionary Council

Keshtmand, 44, may have been given his fairly important posts in the government because he is unlikely to become a rival to Babrak. He is a Hazara in a nation where Pushtuns have always ruled, and a Shia in a predominately Sunni country. His factional loyalties in the party have been unclear, and he was able to accommodate himself enough to Amin and Taraki to escape the July 1978 purge, although he was dismissed as Minister of Planning and jailed during a second purge the following month. His confession published in September implicated Babrak in antigovernment plotting. []

(b)(3)

~~Secret~~

-Secret-

Keshtmand was one of the original founders of the People's Democratic Party in 1965, and when the party split in 1967, apparently sided with Taraki's Khalqists. He was an unsuccessful candidate for Parliament in 1965, but was not so openly leftist to be denied government employment. He became director general of the economics section of the Ministry of Mines in 1965. ☐

(b)(3)

(Shah Mohammad Dost) Foreign Minister

Dost, who entered the diplomatic service in 1956, was Deputy Foreign Minister under Amin. His influence in the ministry, however, apparently was slight because of his connections to the Parchamists. Dost has served in New York, Washington, Islamabad, and Peshawar and as chief of protocol in Kabul. ☐

(b)(1)

(b)(3)



(Faiz Mohammad) Minister of Borders and Tribes

Faiz Mohammad, about 36, is a Soviet-trained Army officer who helped overthrow the monarchy in 1973. He was rewarded with the Interior Ministry, but—probably as part of Daoud's efforts to eliminate leftists from the government—was later demoted to Frontier Affairs, and in 1977 appointed Ambassador to Djakarta. He apparently was not a member of the PDPA, but was regarded as a "good friend" by the Parchamists. He was named Ambassador to Baghdad after the Marxists gained power, but was later dismissed, presumably because of his Parchamist connections. ☐

(b)(3)



(Mohammad Khan Jallalar) Minister of Trade

Jallalar, 44, is a hard-working, competent civil servant and is apparently apolitical with no known connections to the Parchamists. His family fled to Afghanistan in 1930, and he has some distant relatives in the USSR. He is an Uzbek, and possibly a Shia. ☐

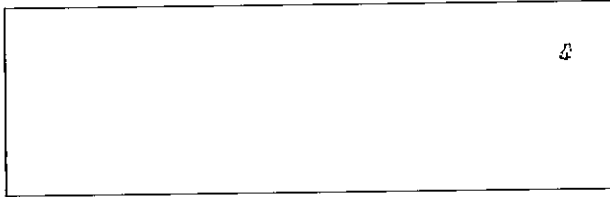
(b)(3)

After graduating from Kabul University in 1958, Jallalar entered the Ministry of Planning. He was appointed Minister of Finance in 1972, in the last Cabinet under the monarchy. Five months after the King was overthrown, Daoud made him Minister of Commerce, a post he held until the Marxist coup in 1978. ☐

(b)(3)

-Secret-

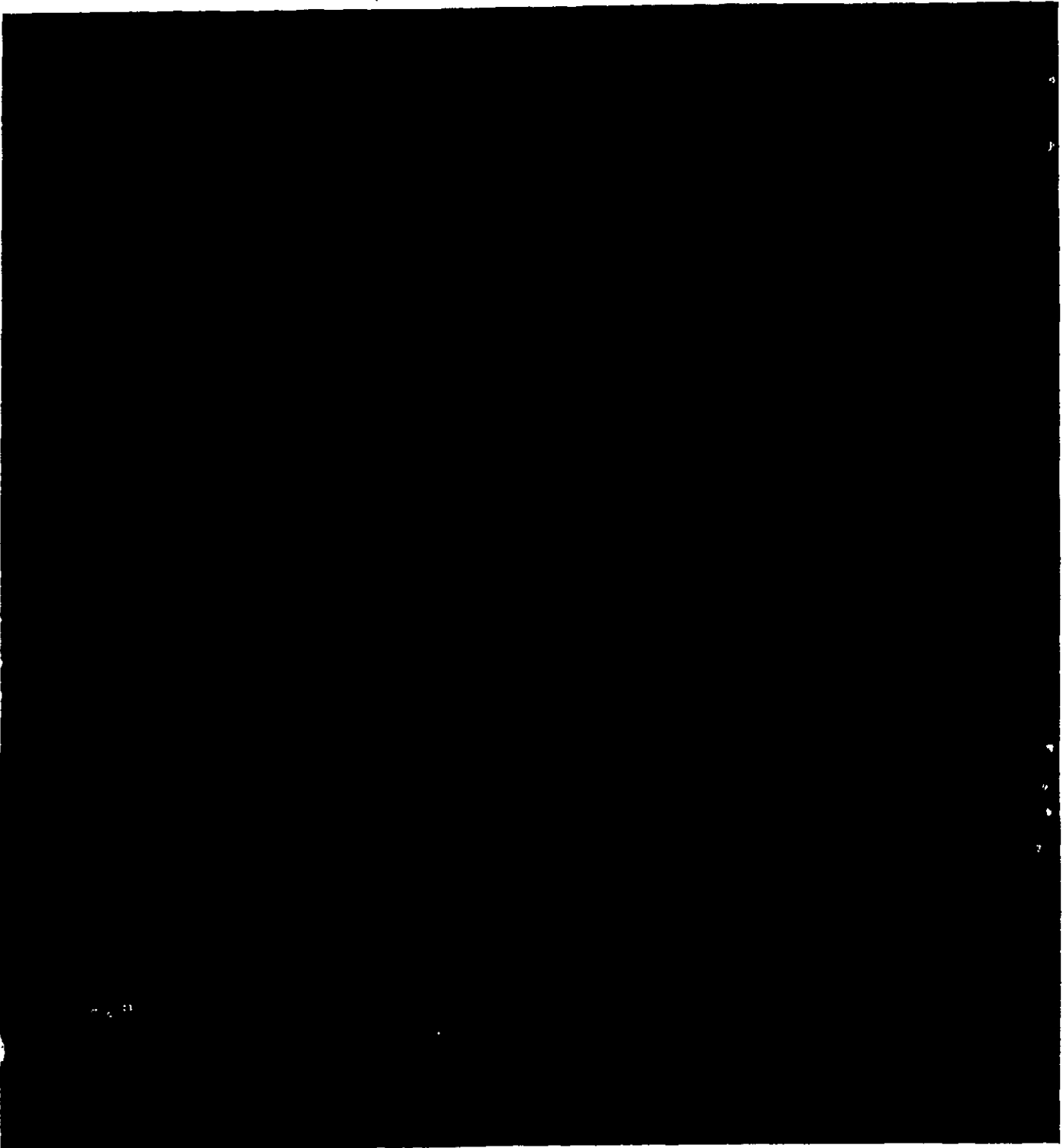
~~Secret~~



(b)(3)

~~Secret~~

~~Secret~~





National
Foreign
Assessment
Center



~~Secret~~

FILE

Babrak Karmal
President and Prime
Minister of Afghanistan ☐

(b)(3)

A Biographic Research Paper

~~Secret~~

CR 80-10062
January 1980

084

**National Security
Information**

**Unauthorized Disclosure
Subject to Criminal Sanctions**

This publication is available
on microfiche.
To get a microfiche copy of this
publication
(OCR/DSB); for future issuances
in addition to or in lieu of
hard copies,
(OCR/ISG).

Original classification by 013787
Review on 16 January 2000
Extended beyond 6 years by 013787
Reason: CGB 7

(b)(3)

(b)(3)

All material on this page is unclassified



National
Foreign
Assessment
Center

~~Secret~~

**Babrak Karmal
President and Prime
Minister of Afghanistan**

(b)(3)

A Biographic Research Paper

Information as of 16 January 1980 has
been used in preparing this report

*The author of this paper is Near
East/Africa Division, Office of Central Reference.
Comments and questions may be directed to Chief,
Near East/South Asia Branch, on*

(b)(3)

(b)(6)

(b)(3)

*This paper was coordinated with the Office of Political
Analysis, the Office of Scientific Intelligence,
and the Directorate of Operations.*

~~Secret~~

CR 80-10062
January 1980

~~CONFIDENTIAL~~**BIOGRAPHIC BRIEF**

On 27 December 1979 Babrak Karmal was installed as the new Afghan President and Prime Minister after a bloody Soviet-backed coup. Babrak has been a Communist political agitator since the early 1950s and leader of the Parcham (Banner) faction of the People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan since 1967. He is a skilled orator and political tactician. [REDACTED] A longtime proponent of closer PDPA ties to the USSR, he owes his political survival during the recent turmoil in Afghan politics to Soviet sponsorship. His expressed attitude toward the United States has always followed the Soviet line. [REDACTED]

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

(b)(3)

iii

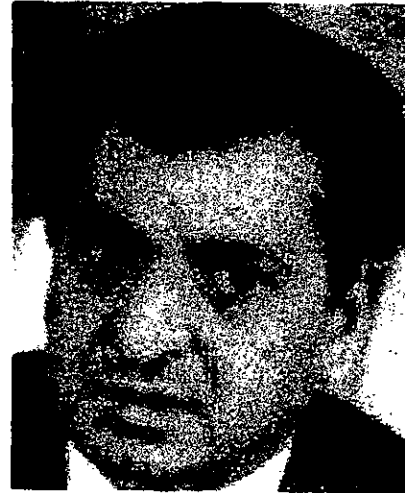
~~CONFIDENTIAL~~

~~SECRET~~

BABRAK Karmal
(Phonetic: baBRUCK)

AFGHANISTAN

President, Revolutionary Council; Prime Minister (since December 1979)



Babrak Karmal was installed as leader of Afghanistan on 27 December 1979, after a violent, Soviet-engineered coup that ousted President Hafizullah Amin. Babrak holds the three most important political positions in the country: he is President of the Revolutionary Council (chief of state), Prime Minister (head of the government), and secretary general of the ruling People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA). Since assuming power in Kabul he has attempted to broaden his domestic political base by including some military leaders and some non-Communist civilians in his Cabinet and on the Presidium of the Revolutionary Council (the main executive body). These moves are unlikely to be enough to win him the support of the general populace (which opposes Soviet intervention in Afghanistan), however, and he will continue to depend on Soviet military support for the survival of his government. ☐

(b)(3)

The Road to Power in Kabul

Babrak is a veteran Communist whose leftwing activities began when he was a student at Kabul University in the late 1940s and early 1950s. Arrested in 1952 for leftist agitation on campus, he spent the next five years in jail, where he renewed an earlier acquaintance with Afghanistan's leading Communist theoretician, Mir Akbar Khaibar, who had been imprisoned for subversion. Under Khaibar's tutelage, Babrak became an active Communist, and he joined the PDPA when it was formed in 1965. The PDPA split in 1967 because of personality clashes and differences over party strategy among its leaders. Babrak and his followers, who favored increased political agitation, formed the Parcham (Banner) faction, while the more cautious Nur Mohammad Taraki and his supporters formed the Khalq (People) faction. Believing that a united party could more forcefully oppose the regime of President Mohammad Daoud, Babrak led the Parchamists back into the party in 1977 after agreeing to serve as vice chairman while Taraki became party head. ☐

(b)(3)

(b)(3)

CR 80-10062

~~SECRET~~

~~—SECRET—~~

In April 1978 Babrak was one of three PDPA members—the others were Taraki and his fellow Khalq faction member Hafizullah Amin—who emerged as leaders of the Democratic Republic of Afghanistan after the coup that overthrew Daoud and established a Marxist regime. Taraki became President and Prime Minister, while Amin was named Foreign Minister and a vice prime minister. Babrak became vice chairman of the Revolutionary Council and a vice prime minister along with Amin. []

(b)(3)

During the spring and summer of 1978 Taraki and other Khalq leaders, including Amin, began to consolidate their power. They were particularly concerned with limiting the influence of Babrak and the Parchamists, who were calling for closer ties to the Soviet Union. In July 1978 Taraki directed a party purge that led to the removal of Parchamists from key government and PDPA positions. Babrak was exiled as Ambassador to Czechoslovakia and was removed from the PDPA Central Committee. In September 1978 he was ordered home to stand trial on charges of coup plotting. He did not return to Kabul, however, but dropped out of sight. One report indicates that during 1979 he made several trips to Moscow. By the time the ambitious Amin had succeeded in ousting Taraki in September 1979, Babrak had still not returned to public life. In late 1979 the Soviets apparently determined that Amin was losing control of Afghanistan and decided that Babrak, the pro-Soviet leader of the Parcham faction of the PDPA, was the logical choice to succeed Amin. Sometime before late December they summoned Babrak to Moscow to inform him of his impending installation as President and Prime Minister of Afghanistan.

[]

(b)(3)

Soviet Puppet

Before the April 1978 coup, most Afghan observers had difficulty assessing Babrak, but they generally concluded that he was little more than a front man for Khaibar. []

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

[] Until Khaibar was killed in April 1978 (perhaps by Muslim extremists), Babrak depended on him for his intellectual inspiration, and Babrak has never won respect as a thinker in his own right. []

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

(b)(1)

(b)(3)

[] In the months immediately after the 1978 coup he proved to be less astute than the scholarly Taraki or the ruthless (b)(1). Babrak managed to survive the power struggle that followed (b)(3) Marxist revolution, however, largely because he relied on the guidance and support of the Soviets. []

(b)(3)

~~—SECRET—~~

~~SECRET~~

Over the years Babrak's publicly expressed attitude toward the United States has fluctuated with the Soviet line. After the 1978 coup, he expressed [] his admiration for the American people and for the great contribution the American Revolution had made to the cause of democracy. In the aftermath of the December 1979 coup, however, he embarked on a virulent anti-US propaganda campaign designed to divert attention from the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan. Because he must depend on the Soviet Union for military support and political guidance, Babrak will probably closely follow Soviet direction in his relations with the United States. []

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

(b)(3)

In his relations with neighboring Pakistan, Babrak may attempt to exploit his Pushtun background. He is a native of Pushtunistan, a large tribal area that straddles over 400 miles of the Pakistan-Afghanistan border. The Pushtuns have demanded autonomy for many years, and in the past Babrak has spoken in favor of a separate Pushtunistan. He may now rekindle tribal demands for autonomy in an attempt to stir up Pushtun insurgency in the Pakistani portion of the region, hoping that unrest in the area will make it easier for Afghanistan to extend its eastern frontier to include all of Pushtunistan or for the Soviets to move beyond the Afghan border and establish a puppet state of Pushtunistan. []

(b)(3)

Early Life and Career

Babrak Karmal was born in 1929 in Kanary into a prominent Pushtun family that may have been related to the late President Daoud. His father is Lt. Gen. (ret.) Mohammad Hussein Khan, who was Governor General of Paktia Province for an unknown length of time before 1975. Babrak graduated from the German-language Nejat High School in Kabul in 1948 and entered the Faculty of Law of Kabul University in 1949. After his release from jail in 1956, he completed his law studies and graduated in 1957. During 1957-58 he served in the Army, and from 1958 to 1965 he was a minor official in the Ministry of Planning. []

(b)(3)

Babrak ran for a seat in the Wolesi Jirgah (lower house of parliament) in September 1965 and won. Parliament provided him with the opportunity to display his skills as an orator and his talents as a political tactician. In October 1965 he was the instigator of antigovernment student disorders that resulted in the fatal shootings of several students and the resignation of the Prime Minister. In November 1966 Babrak and fellow Deputies Nur Ahmad Nur (now a member of the Revolutionary Council) and Anahita Ratebzad (now Minister of

~~SECRET~~

~~SECRET~~

Education) were severely beaten in the Wolesi Jirgah by conservative deputies; Babrak was hospitalized for six weeks, thereby winning the sympathy of university students. He was reelected to the Wolesi Jirgah in September 1969, after a lively campaign in which he was actively supported by students.

(b)(3)

Babrak again found himself in the limelight in July 1971. Using a confidence debate over the appointment of a new prime minister as a reason to take the floor, he delivered an 80-minute speech, in which he made countless denunciations of the King and the royal family; praised the beneficence of the USSR; singled out the United States for special attack, blaming it for all of Afghanistan's economic ills; and urged a new militancy in support of autonomy for Pushtunistan (Babrak was probably not so much concerned with his people's desire for autonomy as with using their demands to strengthen his attack on the government). In other speeches Babrak criticized the Durand Line (the border between Afghanistan and Pakistan), insisting that Afghanistan had never recognized it and never would. He also attacked the Afghan Industrial Development Bank, which he called "evil capitalism incarnate." In March 1973 he led what may have been the largest demonstration in the history of Afghanistan to protest the Iran-Afghanistan agreement to share the waters of the Helmand River, which he believed favored Iran. Babrak's harangues both in and out of parliament stirred his listeners, and he became better known than the Prime Minister of the moment. His career as a deputy ended when parliament was dissolved after the 1973 coup that replaced the monarchy with a constitutional republic under Mohammad Daoud. Babrak refrained from public activity until April 1978, when he made an emotional speech at the funeral of his mentor Khaibar. A short time later he was one of seven Central Committee members arrested in a Communist purge by the Daoud regime.

(b)(3)

Personal Data

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

4
~~SECRET~~

~~SECRET~~

[REDACTED] He speaks Dari and English, some German, and limited Pushtu. [REDACTED]

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

[REDACTED] [REDACTED]

(b)(3)

[REDACTED] Babrak has five brothers. Two, [REDACTED] are active Communists. [REDACTED]

[REDACTED] Babrak is married and has four children, [REDACTED]

[REDACTED] He and Minister of Education Anahita Ratebzad have been lovers since 1960. She was Ambassador to Yugoslavia while Babrak was in Prague. Ratebzad, who is about 50, is the estranged (perhaps divorced) wife of Babrak's uncle, Dr. Karamuddin Kakar, who was dean of the Medical College of Kabul University during 1972-75. [REDACTED]

(b)(1)
(b)(3)

(b)(3)

16 January 1980

5

~~SECRET~~

C06955217

Approved for Release: 2025/06/25 C06955217

~~Secret~~

~~Secret~~

Approved for Release: 2025/06/25 C06955217